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Is the medium the message? Exploring the intersection of social media and collective action in the San José Bike Party

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ABSTRACT

The San José Bike Party (SJBP) is a diverse collective of cyclists gathering for monthly group rides around the urban centre of San José, California. By leveraging social networking platforms, the SJBP announces a route and theme just prior to the ride each month. We argue that organizing, producing, and participating in these rides constitute a political act which can help to promote civic engagement and collective action. Further, we explored the way in which collective action can be fostered via social media. Through analysis of semi-structured individual interviews, focus-group interviews, moving methodologies and field observations derived from researcher participation in SJBP events, we articulate the complexities of contested and negotiated meanings of the use of technology, social media and activism assigned to the event by participants, yielding these themes: Critical Analysis of Social Media's Influence, Political Expressions in the SJBP and Prefigurative Politics in the SJBP.

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Introduction

¹This paper examines the promotion and proliferation of the San José Bike Party (SJBP) in North America and the development and growth of similar Bike Party movements internationally. Following the researched pathways explored in *The Medium is the Message* by McLuhan and Fiore (1967, 123, 126–128), we focus on communication strategies, such as the use of social media employed by SJBP organizers and its participants to circulate information about their rides and to promote social activism through collective action on bikes. As the SJBP and other Bike Party movements worldwide have increased their online presence, while regularly attracting thousands of participants at each event, we argue that organizing, producing, and participating in these group rides constitute a political act which may promote civic engagement and collective action (Obar, Zube, and Lampe 2012). In spite of the potential for collective action via participation, we problematize the extent to which the SJBP democratizes the process of emerging social movements, highlighting the possibilities in addressing the democratic divide among diverse communities.

Bike Party movement

The San José Bike Party (SJBP) is a monthly gathering of 2000–4000 bicyclists who ride a predetermined route, en masse, through the urban streets of San José, California (Chin, Masucci, and Johnson 2020; Johnson, Masucci, and Signer-Kroeker 2018; Stehlin 2019; Terry and Todd 2013). The SJBP draws a diverse crowd (which seems to mirror the diversity of the city itself), the largest city in Northern California of just over 1 million people, whose population according to the census survey as reported in World Population Review (2021) identify as White: 39.91%, Asian: 35.91%, Other race: 14.82%, two or more races: 5.35%, Black or African American: 3.00%, Indigenous: 0.56% or Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander: 0.46%, and promotes a vibrant party atmosphere replete with loud music, decorated bikes, participant costumes and the open consumption of alcohol and marijuana. While there are no published demographics of the participants who take part in any given SJBP event, through researcher participation in multiple rides, participant observations and comments, riders are described as being represented across ages, some very young but most described as mainly adults, of all genders and representative of the population demographics of San José. The ride is open and free to the public, though participants are expected to follow traffic laws and certain prescribed guidelines and rules of the road which are specified on its website, many of which were ‘lifted from the Midnight Ridazz website’ as described on the SJBP webpage. While there is no specific demographic information or research at this point, anecdotal, participants are made aware of the Bike Party through word of mouth, friends, through the website, or their online social media presence and by chance, witnessing a Bike Party as an entry point. The Bike Party is led by a group of volunteer organizers who, often working with local community partners (including local law enforcement, government entities as well as bicycle and cultural advocacy organizations), carefully plan out a new monthly 15–30 miles route which includes intermittent rest/regroup/party stops. The SJBP is self-defined as ‘one-half political party, one-half street party – made up of all types of bicyclists and human-powered transportation advocates who celebrate and build community in a monthly ride’ (www.sjbikeparty.org). Its mission of ‘building community through cycling’ is supported by their vision, as posted on their website, to be sustainable, empowering and inclusive, collaborative and transparent and local. Finally, and not uncontroversially, the SJBP is a 501(c)(3) public charity and was granted tax exempt status in 2016 after incorporating in 2014 as SJ Bike Party, Inc (Wadsworth 2014). While space does not permit a fulsome examination of the broader leadership structure of SJBP in this paper, as Wadsworth (2014) suggests, the idea of incorporation itself was, at the time, met (by some) with suspicion as indicated in the article comments some of which referenced message board and Facebook posts discussing the pros and cons of such a move.

The growth of social media has been integral to the expansion of the SJBP and has led to the establishment of locally adapted bike parties which use the SJBP website, its stated philosophy, and its organizational structure as a model in cities across North America, including Boston, Baltimore, Vancouver, among others, and in international communities such as Paris, Seoul, Auckland and Changwon. The bike parties modelled after the SJBP have adopted similar philosophies (evidenced by the similarity of language and mission to the SJBP webpage as reflected on their respective websites) related to community-building, inclusivity, sustainability, and empowerment through

large group bike rides around the world; launching a global Bike Party Movement that continues to expand.

The Bike Party phenomenon is a movement insofar as it can be characterized as: (1) being in conflict with other opposing ideas, (2) having structure within information networks, and (3) having a collective aim of furthering the ideas presented. Throughout history various forms of communication have been used to strengthen and further such movements (Cammaerts 2015). The SJBP movement is no different in this regard, as it leverages its popularity and participation through multiple communication platforms as it places people and their bicycles at the centre of a unique opportunity to participate in civic engagement, collective action and activity activism. While not without contestation as we will demonstrate below, the Bike Party may be construed variously as; a 'protest carnival' (St. John, 2004); a form of 'Biketivism' (Furness 2005, 2010); a 'Co-incident Performance' (Terry and Todd 2013); a 'Moving Methodology' (Chin, Masucci, and Johnson 2020) and/or a version of 'connective action' (Bennett and Segerberg 2012, 2013) whereby the very act of thousands of riders taking to the streets simultaneously could be characterized as an activist intervention even if tacitly positioned as what Stehlin (2019) calls a 'postpolitical' event (59).

Using social media for civic engagement

Civic engagement is a process that 'involves moving an individual away from disinterest, distraction, ignorance, and apathy and towards education, understanding, motivation, and action' (Obar, Zube, and Lampe 2012, 3). Social media's ability to connect and network like-minded people, share information and attract supporters suggests that it would be an effective tool for civic activism (Marinov and Schimmelfennig 2015). Increasingly, activists are utilizing mobile communication and the Internet to support platforms that empower minority groups to self-represent, communicate and gather together for various social movements globally (Cammaerts 2015).

One of the first occurrences of Internet activism was in 1997 where more than 600 advocacy organizations in almost 70 countries expressed opposition to the Multilateral Agreement on Investment (MAI). The mass online opposition ultimately resulted in the closing of the negotiations. Since then, multiple organizations and initiations have used the Internet to promote and enact change (Obar, Zube, and Lampe 2012). Examples of utilizing social media to engage citizens and create a call for action are abundant in present day world events. Examples include the political uprisings in Tunisia, Libya and Egypt in 2011, where rebels communicated their messages through Facebook and Twitter, the use of Blackberry instant messaging in London by rioters in 2011, Facebook fan support for Senatorial candidates during the USA 2010 midterm elections, and 'FreedomConnector', used in 2011 to mobilize Americans during the presidential race (Obar, Zube, and Lampe 2012). More recent examples explore the use of social media in the Black Lives Matter (BLM) movement. Mundt, Ross, and Burnett (2018), for example, investigated how social media usage helped to promote organization messaging, mobilize participants and build and strengthen coalitions both within and outside of the organization. Wellman (2022) interviewed instagram influencers and their decision to share black squares in lieu of content ostensibly to show solidarity with the BLM movement. Wellman concluded, however, that the act of posting black squares amounted to

'performative allyship' which was strategically deployed in order to build credibility among their followers rather than indicate a deeper commitment of support for the movement over the long term.

In a study conducted by Obar, Zube, and Lampe (2012), researchers asked a variety of organizations if they used social media to interact with citizens, to which 100% of the respondents answered 'yes'. Advocacy groups that were surveyed identified benefits of connecting individuals, promoting engagement by opening opportunities for feedback, strengthening collective action efforts through immediacy, and cost efficiency. Facebook consistently ranked highest among social networking sites for fostering civic engagement and collective action, with Twitter following closely behind.

Using social media for collective action and activity activism

Collective action 'refers to the pursuit of a single goal or multiple goals by more than one individual' (Obar, Zube, and Lampe 2012, 4). When using social media for activism, the medium plays a significant part in supporting inward roles pertaining to base-level organization, decision-making and coordination, as well as outward roles of sharing ideas, strategizing attacks, gathering support and growing the movement (Cammaerts 2015). Working from a single podium, social media, in its many forms, allow groups to widely broadcast messages to multiple targeted groups. Combining traditional forms of communication and social movement tactics with the modern method of sharing such communication on a larger scale, activists are empowered to continue their activism on a platform that is cost effective and immediately global (Cammaerts 2015).

Not only does social media act as a vehicle for immediately relaying information, but it also creates an electronic archive of texts and audiovisual content that can be used in future movements. Therefore, activists, aided by the use of social media, share information relevant to their social movement *and* influence future efforts. When online interaction turns into offline collective actions, ties are strengthened and movements begin through the building of collective actions, identities and purpose. 'Technology is not treated as an end in itself, but is seen as being used strategically to facilitate direct action offline and to integrate mobilization and recruitment strategies with the distribution of information and movement agendas' (Cammaerts 2015, 5). Though the SJBP uses social media to promote its mission and vision, its agenda is physically and mobilized as thousands of bike riders converge and ride through the local streets.

Wilhoit and Kisselburgh (2015) suggest that collective action can take place without any formalized organization or coordination. Bike commuting, for example, may seem like an organized activity among participants who ascribe to particular views about biking, bike infrastructure, and the politics of recognizing the rights of this collective, but, there are actually very few bike commuters in the United States and many of them do not necessarily communicate with each other or bike commuting advocacy groups (Wilhoit and Kisselburgh 2015). In fact, less than 1% of Americans ride bikes to work (Federal Highway Administration 2011). However, while an individual cyclist may have little impact on drivers and city planners, a group of cyclists as a collective can more effectively challenge the spaces within urban areas and create a voice for change (i.e. advocating for bike safety laws). In bike commuting, there is no planned voice or uprising, but

rather it is a collective outcome of combined actions. The act of bike commuting is not an intentional collective action, but rather a reflection of multiple individuals with the same insights or passion expressed through cycling. Still, the collective action of cycling increases the potential to bring about significant change, more so than any one individual would have the power to do on their own (Wilhoit and Kisselburgh 2015).

As Stehlin (2019) reminds us, cycling has gone through at least ‘five distinct political waves since the bicycle first emerged as a mass commodity in the late nineteenth century’ (56). Moreover, many bicycle-centred political movements have taken the form of ‘collective riding’ whereby the intentional massing of bicycles to achieve political ends is used as a strategy to ‘appropriate’ or reclaim city spaces (Stehlin 2019, 56). An example of a collective riding form of collective action can be seen in the Critical Mass movement, where cyclists gather for a monthly ride through the streets of major urban centres (Carlsson 2002, 6). In 1992, about 45 individuals gathered to ride bicycles during rush hour in San Francisco to raise the visibility of bicycling (Blickstein and Hanson 2001; Carlsson 2002; Furness 2007; Williams 2018; Stehlin 2019). Known as ‘Critical Mass’ (CM), this gathering of cycling activists, insolently riding through traffic, quickly became known as a protest, though it was not formally organized. At its inception, there was no established leadership, membership or mission statement. Still, through the use of the Internet, the movement gained popularity to the point of attracting thousands of riders each month, causing much disturbance in the streets of San Francisco, and coalescing their efforts to advocate for safer streets and cleaner air (Blickstein and Hanson 2001).

In contrast to CM, Bike Party rides are clearly organized, with its goals outlined on the SJBP website: aiming to ‘demonstrate a tangible alternative to car-based transportation’ freeing ‘people from costly fees, stuffy cars, sedentary lifestyles, and dreadful commutes’, and ‘collaborate with the many local and regional organizations whose missions dovetail with our own, to name a few (www.sjbikeparty.org).

A tactic used by many activists is using social media ‘to distribute content uploaded by protesters which can go viral and may be picked up by international media’ (Cammaerts 2015, 4). While social media can be used as an impactful vehicle through which to disseminate important messages and enact change, we steer away from the over-optimistic assumption that the internet can serve as a democratizing force for activism where no digital divide exists. The SJBP engages with participants through social media, but its impact and vision is enacted through the collective action that constitutes the Bike Party (Rowse, Morrell, and Alvermann 2017).

Critiques of technology as a democratizing tool

Though technology and social media play a central role in organizing and promoting Bike Party movements across the globe, some scholars argue social media is neither an effective medium, nor a democratized platform. Although immediacy and effortlessness of group mobilization via social media is celebrated, critics argue it does little to strengthen movements and create lasting change (Gladwell 2010; Morozov 2011; Tilly, 2004). It must also be noted that while technologies such as mobile phones, computers and the internet are fairly pervasive throughout the world, they are still costly and limited to some thus perpetuating an inequitable digital divide (Tilly, 2004).

Digital divide refers to the inequality in the accessibility of the Internet between countries both geographically and economically (Norris 2001). Cammaerts (2015) highlights how reducing costs and barriers of participation via online activism comes at the price of 'uneven distribution of access and the need for specific digital skills' (5). Van Laer and van Aelst (2010) further discuss the 'digital divide' in terms of how geographical location plays a significant role in the use and access of this activist evolution. They write,

The digital divide argument goes to the core of many social movements as it weakens their democratic potential. And this is even more apparent in light of the global digital divide, which seriously endangers the representation of a 'global civil society' in the repertoire shift from the national to the transnational level. (1161)

Therefore, if the growth of the SJBP could be in part a result of the Internet, it may become limited in terms of its international proliferation with the uneven access to the Internet in societies across the globe.

Another issue that arises with online activism is the protection of activist group confidentiality. Cammaerts writes, 'the notion of private communication online is being eroded and this has consequences for confidential communication among activists' (6). Further, Van Laer and van Aelst (2010) highlight the limitations of transnational demonstrations going worldwide, saying 'most international protests are in fact overwhelmingly local, or at best national demonstrations' (1161). Indeed, simple awareness via Facebook, Twitter, or other means of social media is not the equivalent of action (Morozov 2011). Digital activism campaigns are described as 'nothing but illusory' by Morozov (2011, 194), where although recruiting new members is easy, having them invest in the task or goal at hand is difficult. 'The internet is unable to create the necessary trust and strong ties that are necessary to build a sustainable network of activists' (Van Laer and van Aelst 2010, 1163). Coordination between online word sharing and real offline actions is needed in order to deem digital advocacy as useful.

Further, a noted phenomenon described as 'slacktivism' and 'clicktivism' is currently one of the primary modes of (minimally) engaging in activism through social media. According to Morozov (2011) slacktivism is a 'civic promiscuity which is usually the result of a mad shopping binge in the online identity supermarket that is Facebook, that makes online activists feel useful and important while having precious little political impact' (190). As an example, Morozov (2011) uses the anti-FARC protests, arguing that the protests were successful not because of their Facebook popularity, but because 'they were opposing a group much hated by the Colombian government' (203). Furthermore,

when the same group of activists used their Facebook know-how to launch similar anti-Chavez protests in Venezuela in September 2009, expecting up to sixty million people to join the protests all over the globe, only a few thousand actually showed up. (Morozov 2011, 203)

Another example outlined is the Facebook page dedicated to 'Saving the Children of Africa'. According to Morozov (2011), with over 1.7 million members, it had only raised approximately \$12,000.

In this way, clicktivism and slacktivism can be viewed as forms of passive engagement that makes the individual feel 'good', as though they have made a political

difference, or at the very least, a political statement. The argument could be made that real or meaningful actions demand a higher commitment and a more physical engagement, participating in a live demonstration or gathering, collectively walking, marching, or biking, for example.

In this paper, we examine participant experiences with Bike Party which are used to develop 3 main themes presented below. An analysis of participant interviews, broadly construed, highlights the influence (and limitations) of social media and electronic communications to support collective action and the proliferation of the SJBP framework. We couple this with an analysis of the use, efficacy and sometimes limits of utilizing social media for political and social movement aims. A primary focus of this paper revolves around how large groups *can* take collective action, and more specifically ‘moving’ collective action, facilitated by the connective influence of social media and linked with physical ‘in person’ activities such as the SJBP, which is particularly intriguing since the Bike Party has historically been framed in non-political terms.

Method

Following Sparkes and Smith (2014), who argue that ‘qualitative research is a form of social inquiry that focuses on the way people interpret and make sense of their experiences and the world in which they live’ (14), this paper is part of a larger multi-year study intended to gain insight into the San José Bike Party. In particular, in this paper, we explore the intersection between technology, social media, politics and (physical) activism. Through the use of qualitative inquiry we employed open-ended questions that revolved around themes of social and political space, social media and the internet, activism and collective action, and physically active space, in order to examine if or how the SJBP may function as a social and activist movement despite its oft-stated non-political framing. Specifically, we used qualitative methods, including moving methodologies (Chin, Masucci, and Johnson 2020), semi-structured one-on-one and focus group interviews (Sparkes and Smith 2014). Our participants included 21 men and women, with varying degrees of Bike Party experience and involvement. The individual interviews lasted from approximately one hour to an hour and a half. Interviews were digitally recorded and transcribed verbatim and took place in a variety of spaces, including on bicycles, at designated party/re-group stops during Bike Party rides, in larger rooms, in smaller rooms, via telephone and over email. Focus group interviews were conducted with two separate groups with five and six participants respectively. In addition to semi-structured and focus group interviews, researchers also joined in several of the Bike Party rides as participants. As engaged participants, we were able to interview other participants ‘on the move’ while immersed in the Bike Party environment (Chin, Masucci, and Johnson 2020; Mayers 2020). In addition to keeping ‘structured and organized field notes’ (Angrosino, 2007, 41), videos of the SJBP events and of the ‘moving’ interviews were recorded by research team members and subsequently analyzed. The observational data collection strategies that were employed helped to provide important context, which informed thick rich descriptions of the event (Lincoln & Guba, 1985; Sheller, 2011). Subsequent analysis of data yielded the following major themes: Critical Analysis of Social Media’s Influence, Political Expressions in the SJBP and Prefigurative Politics in the SJBP.

Results

Critical analysis of social media's influence

Although social media, as a vehicle for facilitating real-time mobilization, is credited for many present day activism spreads, critics argue that social media does little to actually strengthen social movements and create *lasting* change. Further, some critics suggest a sort of delusion is tied in with the evolving Internet world, which may limit democratic strength and ability. This notion has been referred to as 'slacktivism' or 'clicktivism', where individuals put forth little effort (like e-signing a petition with the click of the mouse) and engage with issues in a passive way; the result is a weak protest with minimal movement toward change (Obar, Zube, and Lampe 2012). Morozov (2011) refers to this slacktivism as a 'civic promiscuity – usually the result of a mad shopping binge in the online identity supermarket that is Facebook – that makes online activists feel useful and important while having precariously little political impact' (190). Further, as Van Laer and van Aelst (2010) suggest,

this kind of 'keyboard activism' may go at the expense of real actions that demand a higher commitment. People might not feel motivated to engage in higher threshold actions as they can more easily pursue social and political change by clicking a button and watching some ads. (Van Laer and van Aelst 2010, 1162)

So while the internet and social media have certainly allowed for broader engagement with social and political movements, some have cited a concern that lasting change may be undermined by the lack of long-term commitment and action required to effect lasting change.

When considering the concept of 'clicktivism' as it relates to SJBP, comments by some participants exemplified some of these concerns. R.M, for example, explained how the proliferation of SJBP via social media does not necessarily indicate a productive movement:

Social media is, nobody understands it all the way yet because it, it's uh, ideas that are ... even the 'Gangnam style' can get around the whole planet in 5 days. Everyone knows it. And so an idea that has some serious movement has the ability to explode? Uh anything has the ability to explode. Kittens playing with stuff on YouTube have the ability to explode at this point. (R.M)

This sentiment raises an important point about what gets amplified in the on-line space. The participant seems dubious about the fact that a 'serious social movement' would necessarily get more attention than kitten videos and thus could undermine the social movement message by, at the very least, allowing for a false equivalency ... at least in terms of the amount of engagement with content measured by clicks.

To further punctuate this point, during a focus group interview, when asked, 'What is Bike Party?' one participant replied, 'I think it's something different for everybody' (T.P), to which fellow participants agreed. Similarly, when Justin was asked about his understanding of what the Bike Party represents, he remarked, 'it represents something different for everyone'. The participants' responses indicate unclear motives and purpose for individuals involved in Bike Party, perhaps indicating that even if the core organizers had overt political motives for the organization, these objectives may be sublimated at the

individual level. Similarly, when asked if she had been on the SJBP website, Julia replied, 'Yeah. A while ago. I haven't been on it in a while. So I don't remember what it says'. Like Julia, other SJBP participants may come to enjoy the rides and atmosphere of SJBP without much engagement with the social media sites save for checking to see the ride route, which is exclusively posted on electronic platforms.

Though 'virtual activism' (6) on social media may create anecdotal evidence for change (Obar, Zube, and Lampe 2012), some scholars argue that social media can create little lasting change. In his book, *The Net Delusion: The Dark Side of Internet Freedom*, for example, Murphy (2012) outlines how the Internet limits democratic possibilities. He writes:

... the Internet, with its promise of fostering 'virtual communities' on the cheap and widely advertised by the earlier generation of cyber-utopians as something of a panacea to many of modern democracy's ills, has driven the costs of joining such groups to zero. But it's hard to imagine how it could, all by itself, help cultivate a deep commitment to serious causes. (189)

Going further, Morozov quotes Oxford University's Alan Ryan, 'the Internet is good at reassuring people that they are not alone, and not much good at creating a political community out of the fragmented people that we have become' (189). One of the SJBP participants, Hugo, spoke to 'the desire for such a real and intimate community within the SJBP'. However, in his experience with the rapid growth of the SJBP, he felt the development of a meaningful community was unattainable: 'Just speaking for me, kind of stopped going because it got so big, cause it got, it got kind of wild, it was cool having that small group but then, ya know with more people comes more issues'. Hugo's response also may be an example of the lack of commitment that comes with a free event. T.P. also recalled the rapid growth of SJBP as well as a Bike Party where,

We had like 1300 or something like that and that was just like humongous. It went from ... it just grew so quickly and so fast and it felt like in my world at least, in my world with all of my friends it felt like everybody was doing Bike Party, or everyone wanted to do Bike Party you know, and now it seems like I don't even hear about it.

It is unclear whether participation in the online fora has detracted or subtracted from the foundational purpose of the Bike Party. Hugo discussed Bike Party in terms of a movement and needing a purpose, but states:

... but if you start to say like you know we're 'riding for AIDS', you know, we ride for, ya know, 'trouble in Somalia' or something like, you're ... not everyone associates themselves with those kinds of causes. So, you know yeah it's like we're gonna 'ride for gay marriage', you know would be a big one. Like right now we're gonna ride for it. Well, plenty of people are going to ride for it, sure, but then you're gonna be like, like 'nah', ya know, I'm like not gonna do that. *I'm not an activist, they don't want to be an activist, they want to party* [emphasis added]!

When considering this effect, Morozov's (2011) words may ring true: 'Most popular social networking sites were not set up for activists by activists; they were created for the purposes of entertainment and attract activists not because they offer unique services but because they are hard to block' (193).

Social media for Bike Party promotion and proliferation

Part of the influence of social media in the Bike Party 'movement' was the seeming importance of these platforms to both promote and help to expand Bike Party events beyond San José, California. Digital networking technologies, and specifically the use of different forms of social media, have significantly expanded the capabilities of communicative practices (Cammaerts 2015) and Mayers and Glover, provide specific insight of how Safe cycling spaces are both produced and experienced by cyclists (2020).

As explored elsewhere, Johnson, Masucci, and Signer-Kroecker (2018) articulate that the rapid growth and spread of the SJBP can be attributed at least in part to social media (19). Expanding on this notion, one SJBP participant, 'Rasta Man', stated, 'It's not like bikes are anything new, bikes have been around forever [and] people have been using them forever. Without social media this wouldn't be what it is, at all'.

The Internet as a social place provides a forum where individuals can find opportunities for active recreational activities. Specific to the SJBP, there is a website where any person searching Google for biking, outdoor, and San José, is likely to come across this event. Marinov and Schimmelfennig (2015) explain further,

When people join (like) a Facebook page dedicated to a cause, one of the first things they usually see is that there are others who care about the same thing. When the numbers start to climb, an individual joiner is likely to increase their optimism about the odds of success. (9)

A unique feature of social media is that social movements can be shared, developed and expanded on a global level, creating large networks worldwide, which can then be mobilized in multiple places at one time (Cammaerts 2015). A Facebook search turns up countless Bike Party pages (which overwhelmingly have used the SJBP webpage and format as a template), with locations across the United States, Canada, and further into South America, Europe and Asia.

Though participants clearly understood the value in social media for sharing information about SJBP, they did not discredit the impact of word of mouth. The Punisher explained that when SJBP started, he himself wasn't even on Facebook; and when it began around 15 years ago, they didn't have daily interactions via social media. Though there was some debate over SJBP's existence apart from social media, participants agreed that the immense growth would not have been possible without the help of online sharing. 'Trying to build something this big from word of mouth only' (R.M) would not be possible. Similar to the way in which word spreads about SJBP, ideas can get around the whole planet in 5 days. Everyone knows it. And so an idea that has some serious movement has the ability to explode (R.M). In another example, Shannon described how she put a picture of herself on Facebook, 'looking all gangster on their bikes', and immediately other Facebook users responded to her post, asking about the event and giving her an opportunity to advertise the Bike Party.

In the last ten years, the SJBP has exploded globally. A prime example is in Seoul, where the founder 'came here and went to Seoul and just copied it' (Speaker 2). With the help of social media, it spread, and the Seoul Bike Party Facebook Group now has 808 members. The SJBP Facebook page and SJBP website and other social media vehicles inform participants of the location and time of the ride start, the designated route, and theme. Angela explains, 'you can find it [the route] through the Facebook

page and sometimes you can find it on the website', however 'the real routes aren't posted until the night before'. Angela also shared how social media allowed her to share the SJBP with her family, 'I showed my family like videos of Bike Party because [they asked], "what's this Bike Party you guys are talking about?", so I just showed them YouTube videos'. Indeed, these internet sources have been used as an exact blueprint by other Bike Party organizers starting Bike Parties in their host cities; for example, Bike Parties across North America have copied the SJBP webpage nearly verbatim, including the ethos and practices of the original SJBP.

The general availability and accessibility (in the developed world at least) of social media content created by SJBP and other Bike Parties, has served to increase their visibility to potential riders, facilitated communication, provided online meeting sites for Bike Party and non Bike Party related events and topics, and has allowed the Bike Party to spread around the world.

Political expressions in the SJBP

In Aldred's 2013 study, interest in cycling was reported as political by participants, rather than as an interest in bikes themselves. It was seen as producing an identity and taking part in a movement. However, Aldred writes, 'politicizing cycling is itself potentially limiting' (198). In terms of Londoners on Bikes, they aimed to influence the Mayor's role in transportation and urban space affairs through bicycle advocacy (Aldred 2013). Despite its unique characteristics and community-building goal, the SJBP demonstrates evidence of a cloaked political movement as well. Participants' comments about taking back the streets and changing transportation point to political overtones. The streets as a contested space comes into play, and some participants' aim is to claim back the space. 'It's part of doing this thing that we are going to occupy one or more lanes on the streets for tonight and take back the streets' (Speaker 2). With the cost of cars, many explore different modes of transportation. Speaker 2 highlights that the act of bicycling is oppressed and discouraged by laws and bad street designs, stating, 'Streets assume that there will not be people riding bikes around there'.

Fewer opportunities, and discontent with the political system and the current transportation system were all expressed. 'There was some intent that having a good time in the street [would] have a transformative effect' (Speaker 1). Better infrastructure to accommodate biking was proposed, calling upon politicians to be accountable for improving safety. Not only were participants advocating for a change in public transportation, but also a shift to non-motor transportation. The Facebook page also included such political talk. According to the Bike Party founders, there was indeed a political aspect in the foundational development of Bike Party. As one participant reflected,

My idea of politics is we need to stop voting for oil companies into gas pump and I got to say that Bike Party has spread bike wisdom like much deeper into the crevices of San José's people. Bicycles are much more frequently used [as a] transportation alternative than they used to be. And I am sure that four dollar [per]gallon gas has a lot to do with that too but I think we helped. (Speaker 4)

Likewise, Justin recalled seeing people with signs on their bikes for various causes. 'A silent war on oil' as another example.

Prefigurative politics in the SJBP

Prefigurative politics 'refers to scenarios where protesters express the political "ends" of their actions through their "means"' and 'anticipates or partially actualizes goals sought by movements' (Yates, 2014, 3). In the attempt to 'norm' the act of bicycling in the midst of a sedentary and car-dependent society, Bike Party does just that. Alternatively, it suggests that road spaces should be shared and celebrated around the globe. Contrary to the Critical Mass movement, where there is no structure, Bike Party includes pre-planning and a pre-ride that collects information and is then further shared with party members prior to the ride. The over 20-year old Critical Mass movement, which was seen as *the* bike movement, seems to be switching over to Bike Party. SJBP utilizes a specific website text, philosophies and its organizing structure via the internet as a model for rapid and prolific creation of bike parties across North America and internationally. In fact, when asked about the SJBP being a political movement, Scott replied with 'Not per se, it's more of a "movement" to show how much fun one can have on a bike; there may be subtle political undertones, such as bikers rights to SHARE the road, but that's it'. While there seems to be a distancing between Bike Party and politics within language, the undertones and characteristics consistently emerge. Similarly, Nick shared that Bike Party participants share ideas and passions, almost like a political party, though he didn't name it as such.

We've come up with something that is essentially a political movement where we all agree on our tactics but we don't agree on our goals which is a little bit strange but kind of convenient in its own right because it's the opposite of what most people normally do. Most people get together, a meeting of people who all think exactly alike and then they can't agree on anything to do after that and it never goes beyond a meeting. (Nick)

Bike Party does the opposite, where participants agree to take part in Bike Party the third Friday of every month, but that becomes the extent of their action. As Nick further describes:

We're really not about doing anything else other than Bike Party. It's [a] ride that has this style and follows these rules, and really that's all we're about and if you agree with that and think that's cool and fun please join us and we'll talk about how that indicates how we have a lot in common, but really this is the one thing that we are doing.

This would in fact suggest that Bike Party participants express their political ends through the actions of bicycling in Bike Party. There is a sense of a new and novel idea in the Bike Party, which has multiple meanings. Rob referred to this as a subculture, 'this whole cycling culture of people just out riding to ride, to just move around'. Prefiguration, in a sense, is how the Bike Party was formed. There is an expression of self, of politics, of group politics and of the arts.

In addition, prefigurative politics aim to counter institutes and challenge hierarchical values (Yates, 2014). As discussed previously, the act of cycling in and of itself is a counteracting notion to today's auto mobilized world. The act of cycling in the midst of a widely known and described sedentary society is in itself challenging to societal institutes. Julia included, 'Maybe the whole process is just encouraging people to get on their bikes in everyday life, not just for Bike Party'. She also made mention of how SJBP further transformed the actions of her friends. 'They went to it [SJBP] a couple

times and now they ride to the store, and everywhere they go, they want to take their bike if they can' (Julia).

Discussion and conclusions

As Wilhoit and Kisselburgh (2015) discuss, participating in biking activities such as bike commuting is contradictory to the normative practices on road spaces which privileges motor vehicles. Indeed, drivers' interactions towards cyclists on the road are reason to believe that cyclists are yet to be welcomed in these spaces. In this way, 'cycling takes place in opposition to the normative meanings and practices of the road' (11). The growth and collective of bike commuters creates a daily presence on road spaces that challenges normative attitudes and infrastructure that do not cater to cyclists. With the increase of cyclists, drivers' attitudes can be improved if they become more aware of bicycles on the road and increase their own caution (Wilhoit and Kisselburgh 2015). Moreover, the argument of planners remains that because there are few cyclists, infrastructure is not needed. Still, cyclists argue that a small percentage of cyclists are due to infrastructure that does not allow for safe or effective cycling. An environment that does not welcome cyclists does not grow the community of cyclists (Wilhoit and Kisselburgh 2015). This struggle over the contested spaces between bicyclists and automobile users is a political fight of its own and has been well documented in the mobility, transportation, leisure, geography and recreation literature.

While space does not permit a fulsome examination of the leadership structure of SJBP in this paper, as Wadsworth (2014) suggests the idea incorporation itself was, at the time, met with suspicion as indicated in the article comments and referenced in message board and Facebook posts. We suggest a deeper exploration of the leadership structure in future work. This could include an exploration of the means necessary to share public spaces (for transportation and recreation), and at what cost and effort ... both financially and politically. Specifically, future work should include an analysis of if and how the SJBP movement is actually creating a tangible (call for) change in infrastructure, planning and development. With obvious political potential, what, if any, political power does SJBP have (or could have), to advocate for, as Dill and McNeil (2013) recommend, a safe cycling foundation in order to create spaces for those who are 'interested but concerned' in trying to increase participation in cycling (especially for equity-seeking groups). Moreover, an important yet related discussion about access to safe cycling infrastructure has to do with a broader engagement around issues of equity, access and inclusion, as exemplified in the research of Dill and McNeil 2013; Karner et al. 2020 among others. McCullough and van Stokkum (2021), for example, offer tools for practice in public participation as advocates and agents of change with regard to equity and social justice inclusion.

Further, if social media does indeed impact people's optimism about and their participation in physical activity, such as is experienced in the San José Bike Party, there are considerable implications. Not only could this alter the modes of health advocacy, but it could also engage more citizens in every day community building, activity centred and environmentally sustaining events. The perceived motives of cyclists often group them into categories among cyclists. Still, individual benefits and motivations are prevalent among cyclists and seem to accompany collective actions of environmental and awareness motivators (Wilhoit and Kisselburgh 2015). Contrarily, it also raises the question of social

media's ability to have individuals collaborate, develop connections and strength for collective actions in functions and purposes that do not impact society in positive ways.

Social media critics continue to question the long-term impacts and effects of online activism. It is suggested that individuals engage passively through the online world. While there is evidence of large proliferation of the SJB, could it be argued that it is a result of word of mouth, or close personal relations, rather than the impact of social media? One of the SJB's founders discussed the SJB's initial growth, explaining, 'It hit that point and when we were still leaf letting marketing, telling, emailing people, it could only grow in a slow linear fashion, once it hit word of mouth, it started to grow exponentially' (Nick). This is highly significant when considering Gladwell's (2010) stance on the Civil Rights movement of the 1960s, where he claims that personal connections were the foundation to the strong movement. Instead, he suggests that online networks do not withstand challenges and are not long term. Morozov (2011) concludes, 'while it may be true that new forms of activism are emerging, they may be eroding rather than augmenting older, more effective forms of activism and organizing' (2013).

In addition, if the proliferation of the SJB is in fact a result of social media, it is unclear what leads to the vast age range of participants despite the evident drawbacks of generational and digital literacy gaps. Obar, Zube, and Lampe (2012) also mention the need for personal connection for there to be effective mobilization. This would suggest that there is indeed an aspect of personal distribution contributing to the SJB's increasing growth, but to what extent?

Beyond the narratives of Bike Party participants, whose experiences form and inform the themes presented here which centre on the influence of media to support collective action and the proliferation of the SJB framework, we also present a critique of social media influence on political organization. Still, this research has highlighted how large groups *can* take collective action, and in this case 'moving' collective action, facilitated by the connective power of social media in forms of demonstrations and media campaigns.

Bennett and Segerberg (2012, 2013, 2014) advance a theory of connective action whereby the logic of collective action is supplanted by 'connective action' in which 'participation and engagement become highly flexible and personalized' (Gerbaudo and Treré 2015, 867). Accordingly, due to technology, action can take place without 'collective identity framing' that had been historically understood to be a prerequisite of lasting social movements. Moreover, according to Bennett and Segerberg (2012), the use of digitally networked action (DNA) leads to nimble reshaping of social movements due to sharing capacity. While this notion is not without critics (see Gerbaudo and Treré 2015 for example), it may open a window of insight to help make sense of the seeming disparate motives of SJB participation and the potential of collective action when understood as a co-mingling of the power of social media and the materiality (neoliberal critiques notwithstanding) and phenomenological experience of and through the bike are unifying features. Chin, Masucci, and Johnson (2020) explore how researchers can navigate these complex intersections, in part, by employing 'mobile' methods designed to better 'understand the meanings and relationships of people with their bikes and their participation in social bike movements such as the San Jose Bike Party' (14).

Accordingly, due to technology, action can take place without 'collective identity framing' with Bike Party Facebook pages emerging globally and the use of social

media platforms to leverage its multiple messages, some more benign and related to the structure and the commerce of the Bike Party while others more politically overt, the continued proliferation is indisputable and the overarching long-term impact has yet to be determined. With the eventual mitigation of the COVID-19 pandemic, it will be interesting to see the reemergence and the impact of collective physical movements like the San José Bike Party; particularly in light of the renewed interest in and purchase of bikes across North America.

Note

1. The COVID-19 pandemic has directly impacted many of our physical and social interactions and has severely disrupted our physical cultures. With that proviso, it is important to mention that this interactive and continuing research took place prior to the pandemic which struck the world over a year ago and led to governments shutting down many public events like the San José Bike Party (SJBPP). While the SJBPP (and other Bike Parties) have worked diligently over the past year to provide various experiences involving riders and bicycles, including solo scavenger hunts, 'endless' rides that encourage riders to join at any point and in any direction or a suggested route, and the first ride back was the Orange Mask Ride, announced on (5/16/2021) a return to the format of rides that are reflected here in the data, narratives and experiences of those, including ourselves, who took part in these Bike Parties pre COVID-19.

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